Lesson 2 · Spot a phishing message · for your pupils

Scam or safe?

40 minutes | Ages 10–16 · adapt for other ages below | ✓ No electricity needed | ✓ No devices needed | ✓ Photocopy-friendly

Big question

How can we tell if a message is trying to trick us?

Pupils will be able to...

- Name five warning signs of a scam message.
- Sort printed messages into “scam” and “safe” and point to the warning sign.
- Explain how to check a message another way, such as asking a trusted adult.

You need

- Board and chalk (or paper on the wall)
- 8 handwritten or printed message cards per group (see prep)
- Worksheet: Scam detective (one per pair, optional)

Before class

Write eight short messages on cards, four scams and four safe. Scams: a prize, an urgent fee, a request for a code, a link from an unknown number. Safe: a timetable, a sports reminder, a library notice, a parents’ meeting. Make one set per group.

Time	What you do	What you can say	Pupils
Warm-up 0–5 min	Tell the gate story: a stranger says, “The head teacher sent me for the exam papers.” Ask pupils what they would do.	*“Would you hand them over? How could you check whether the story is true?”*	Suggest ways to check: ask the head teacher, go to the office.
Teach 5–13 min	Explain phishing: a message that pretends to be someone you trust. Write the five warning signs on the board, each with a small drawing: clock, link, mask, key, gift.	*“Phishing messages pretend to be someone you trust. If you see a warning sign, stop — and check another way.”*	Copy the five signs; suggest one example of each.
Scam sort 13–27 min	Groups get eight message cards. They sort them into “scam” and “safe” piles and write the warning sign on each scam card. Walk around and ask groups to explain one choice.	*“Which warning sign do you see? What would you do next?”*	Sort the cards, name the signs and agree as a group.
Share 27–34 min	Each group reads one scam card aloud and says what they would do: stop, tell a trusted adult, check another way, then report and delete.	*“If you click by mistake, don’t hide it. Close the page and tell an adult straight away.”*	Read a card; explain the safe next step.
Wrap-up 34–40 min	Exit ticket: each pupil writes one warning sign and one safe action. Collect a few and read them out.	*“Tonight, show someone at home one of the five warning signs.”*	Complete the exit ticket.

Check understanding
Listen for named signs — “it’s urgent”, “it asks for a code” — not just “it looks fake”. If pupils say “it has mistakes”, ask: “What if the spelling were perfect?”

Exit ticket
One warning sign + what I would do if I saw it.

Common mix-ups

Pupils may think…	Help them see…
Scams always have bad spelling.	Show a scam card with perfect spelling. Ask what it wants — money, a code, a click? That’s the real test.
If a friend sends it, it’s safe.	Accounts can be stolen. If a friend asks for money or a code, check by calling or asking in person.
If I clicked, I should hide it.	Telling an adult quickly limits the damage. Make it a class rule: nobody gets in trouble for reporting a mistake.

Adapt it

Younger pupils
Ages 6–9: use three picture messages — a prize, a stranger asking for a secret, a note from the teacher — and one rule: if unsure, ask a trusted adult.

Older pupils and university
Pupils write their own scam message using two warning signs, swap with another group and spot the signs. Discuss why scammers use urgency.

Large classes
Read the messages aloud instead of handing out cards. Pupils show thumbs down for scam and thumbs up for safe; one row explains each answer.

No board or no space
Put a “scam” sign and a “safe” sign on two walls or trees. Read a message; pupils walk to their answer.

Short on time? Do the gate story, the five signs and four message cards as a whole class (20 minutes).

What you need to know

Phishing messages pretend to be someone you trust and push you to act fast. Stop, look for the warning signs, and check through another channel before you click, pay or share.

Phishing
A message that pretends to come from someone you trust, like a bank or ministry, to trick you into clicking, paying or sharing secrets.

Attachment
A file sent with a message, such as a document or photo. An unexpected attachment can hide software that harms your phone or steals data.

Link
Words or a web address you tap to open a page. A phishing link can open a fake page that looks real and asks for your password.

Another channel
A different way to reach the real person or company, like calling a number you already have. Never use the number or link in the message.

My notes — how did it go?